The Baccarat Gladiator Field Guide

THE DEFINITIVE REFERENCE & STRATEGY MANUAL

From 15th-century Italian courts to the high-limit rooms of Macau and Las Vegas — everything you need to play, understand, and enjoy the world's most profitable casino game.

PRACTICE FREE AT

BaccaratGladiator.com

All 5 roads · EZ & Tiger modes · Card squeeze · No account needed

10 CHAPTERS · RULES · ROADS · STRATEGY · HISTORY · FAMOUS CHARACTERS

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1 Why Baccarat?

In 1490, French soldiers returning from the Italian Wars brought a card game back to the court of King Charles VIII. It was simple — two hands, fixed rules, no decisions to make. The king was, by all accounts, a poor gambler. The game was designed so that even he couldn't make a costly mistake. The cards decided everything.

He played anyway. He lost.

Six hundred years later, in the high-limit rooms of Macau and Las Vegas, the same game is being played for tens of millions of dollars a session by some of the wealthiest people on the planet. The rules haven't changed. The house still wins in the long run. And the players keep coming back.

That's the paradox of baccarat: it is simultaneously the simplest game in the casino and the one that generates more money than any other. It requires no skill, no memory, no strategy — and yet it commands a loyalty and mystique that blackjack and poker, for all their complexity, can rarely match.

> "*Baccarat is the only game where the house's advantage is so small that your biggest enemy isn't the casino — it's yourself.*"

THE NUMBERS

85%
MACAU CASINO REVENUE
Baccarat's share of total GGR in the world's largest casino market

#1
TABLE GAME WORLDWIDE
By total revenue generated globally — above blackjack, roulette, and poker

1,400+
US BACCARAT TABLES
Up from ~50 in 1990 — driven by Asian-American players and VIP tourism

WHY AMERICANS ARE DISCOVERING IT NOW

For decades, baccarat was seen in the United States as an Asian game — played in curtained-off VIP rooms by high rollers, invisible to most casino visitors. That is changing. The rise of online baccarat, streaming culture, and a generation of American players who grew up watching Macau content on YouTube has brought the game into the mainstream.

Baccarat now generates more revenue on the Las Vegas Strip than blackjack, despite having fewer tables. The average baccarat bet is larger, the pace is faster, and the ritual of the squeeze — slowly peeling back a card at the edge — has become one of the most-shared casino moments online.

THE CULTURE

No other casino game has a ritual. Blackjack players signal with hand gestures. Roulette spins and settles. But baccarat has the squeeze — a theatrical, deliberate reveal of the card that turns a fraction of a second into a minute of suspended breath. In high-limit rooms, players are handed the card and allowed to bend it slowly, peek at the corner, pull back the edge. The whole table watches.

This is not incidental to the game. It is the game. The mathematics of baccarat are fixed and immovable, so the experience becomes the product — and the squeeze is the climax of that experience.

> **Practice the squeeze free:** Baccarat Gladiator's theatrical card squeeze lets you peel the corner, pull the edge, and snap to full reveal — with sounds — before you ever set foot in a casino.

2 The Rules

Two hands are dealt — **Player** and **Banker**. You bet on which will be closer to 9. That is the entire premise. No skill decides who wins; the cards fall by fixed rules every single time.

CARD VALUES

Cards	Value	Example
Ace	1	A♠ = 1
2 through 9	Face value	7♦ = 7
10, Jack, Queen, King	0	K♣ = 0 · 10♥ = 0

> **Key rule:** Only the last digit counts. 7 + 8 = 15 → scores **5**. 9 + 9 = 18 → scores **8**. K + 4 = 14 → scores **4**.

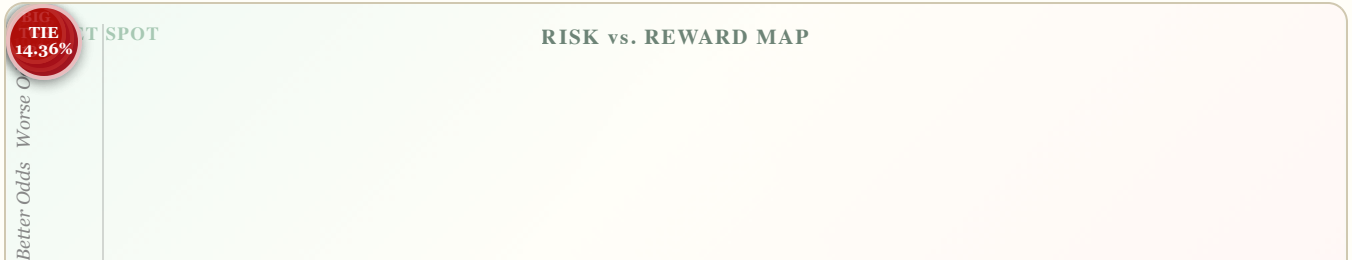
HOW A HAND PLAYS OUT

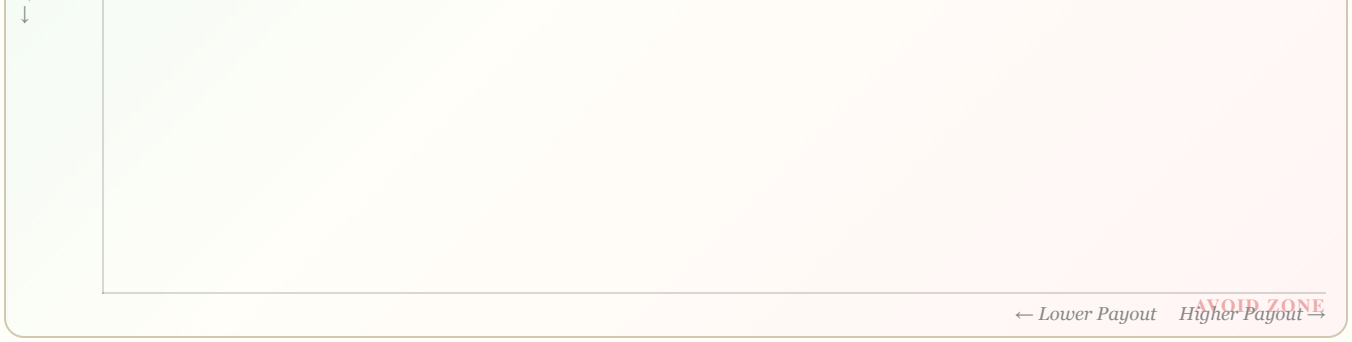
Both Player and Banker receive two cards. A total of **8 or 9** on the first two cards is a **Natural** — the hand ends immediately. Otherwise, a third card may be drawn (see Chapter 3). The hand closest to 9 wins. On a tie, Tie bets pay; Banker and Player bets push.

PAYOUTS & HOUSE EDGE

Bet	Payout	House Edge	Notes
Banker	0.95:1	**1.06%**	5% commission on wins
Player	1:1	**1.24%**	Even money, no commission
Tie	8:1	**14.36%**	Banker/Player push on tie
Player Pair †	11:1	**10.36%**	First two Player cards match
Banker Pair †	11:1	**10.36%**	First two Banker cards match

† Pair bets pay 11:1 at most casinos, 10:1 at some. Confirm at your table.





Bubble size reflects relative bet popularity. House edge % shown inside each bubble. Top-left = best. Bottom-right = worst.

Best bet: Banker at 1.06% is one of the lowest house edges in any casino game. Over 1,000 hands at $10/hand, expected loss is just $106.

Worst bet: Tie at 14.36% loses nearly the same $10 every 7 hands on average. The 8:1 payout feels exciting — the math is brutal.

EZ BACCARAT SIDE BETS

Bet	Trigger	Payout
Dragon 7	Banker wins with 3-card total of 7	**40:1**
Panda 8	Player wins with 3-card total of 8	**25:1**
Big Tiger	Banker wins with 3-card total of 6	**50:1**
Small Tiger	Banker wins with 2-card total of 6	**22:1**
Tiger Tie	Both hands total 6	**35–45:1** ‡

‡ Tiger Tie payout varies by casino (35:1 to 45:1). Baccarat Gladiator pays 35:1.

3 Third-Card Rules

No one chooses whether a third card is drawn — the rules are fixed and automatic. The dealer applies them the same way every hand, in every casino, in every country. You never need to memorize this table to play, but understanding it demystifies the hands that seem to defy logic.

PLAYER THIRD-CARD RULE

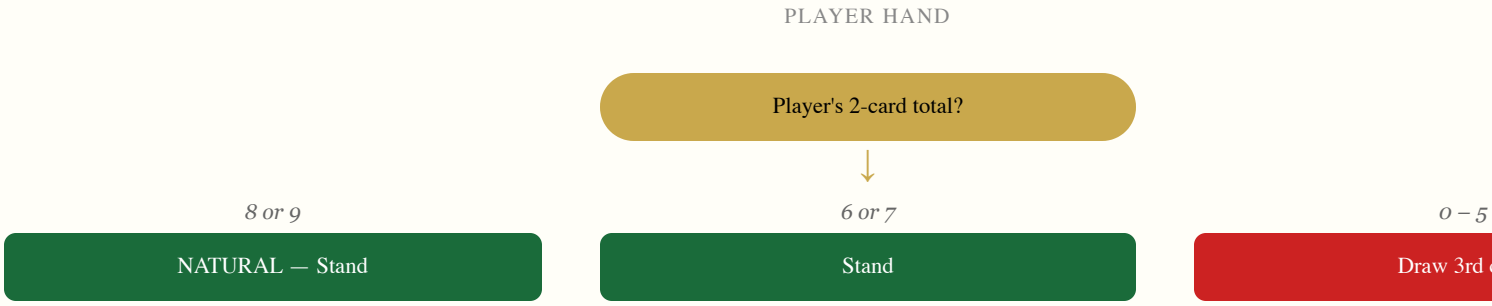
Player Total (first 2 cards)	Action
0 – 5	**Draws a third card**
6 – 7	**Stands**
8 – 9	**Natural — no draw, hand ends**

BANKER THIRD-CARD RULE (WHEN PLAYER DREW)

Banker Total	Draws when Player's 3rd card is…	Stands when…
0, 1, 2	Always draws	—
3	0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 9	8
4	2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7	0, 1, 8, 9
5	4, 5, 6, 7	0, 1, 2, 3, 8, 9
6	6, 7 (only if Player drew)	0–5, 8, 9
7	Always stands	
8 – 9	Natural — hand ends	

> **Memory shortcut:** Banker on 3 draws on everything except an 8. Banker on 6 only draws if Player's third card was 6 or 7. Otherwise: draw on low totals, stand on high.

VISUAL DECISION FLOWCHART



4 Reading the Road Maps

Every baccarat table displays five live tracking grids — the roads. They record the history of every hand in the current shoe. They do not predict the future. Baccarat has no memory; each hand is statistically independent. But the roads have a purpose that pure math misses: they are a shared language, a social tool, and a psychological anchor that experienced players use to pace their betting.

Key: ● Blue = Banker · ● Red = Player · ● Green = Tie

① BIG ROAD — THE PRIMARY SCORECARD

Results fill columns left to right. A new column begins when the result changes. Ties mark the current cell without starting a new column. Tall columns = streaks. Short alternating columns = chops.

② BEAD PLATE — RAW RESULTS GRID

A simple grid filling top-to-bottom, left-to-right. No grouping by streak. 36 results visible at once. Use it for a fast count of how many Banker vs. Player wins are in the current shoe.

③④⑤ DERIVED ROADS — BIG EYE BOY, SMALL ROAD, COCKROACH

All three are derived from the Big Road by comparing columns at different offsets. They show whether the shoe is **regular** (repeating pattern, blue entries) or **choppy** (irregular, red entries).

Road	Starts from	What it shows
Big Eye Boy	2nd column	Short-term regularity
Small Road	3rd column	Medium-term pattern
Cockroach	4th column	Long-range pattern

WHAT EXPERIENCED PLAYERS ACTUALLY DO WITH THE ROADS

Veteran players don't use the roads to predict outcomes — they use them to find *entry points* that feel consistent with recent patterns, and to manage session pacing. A player who sees a strong Banker streak on the Big Road might wait until it breaks before switching sides. A player watching all three derived roads flash red simultaneously might reduce bet size until the shoe settles.

None of this changes the house edge. But it creates a decision framework that prevents impulsive large bets in the middle of a chaotic shoe — and that discipline, over many sessions, is worth more than any system.

Road Prediction: Baccarat Gladiator shows what the next entry on each derived road would be for both a Banker and Player outcome — before cards are dealt. Tap 🔮 Predict to see live projections.

5 The Myth of Systems

Every casino in the world has a gift shop. Almost every gift shop sells a baccarat system booklet. Some casinos hand them out for free. That should tell you something.

No betting system can change the house edge. This is not an opinion — it is a mathematical certainty. The house edge is built into each individual hand. It does not matter what you bet on the previous hand, how many consecutive Bankers have appeared, or what the roads are showing. The next hand's probability is identical to every hand that came before it.

> "*A system that tells you to double your bet after a loss doesn't change the odds — it changes how much of your money the house takes on bad runs*."

THE GAMBLER'S FALLACY

After six consecutive Banker wins, many players feel that Player is "due." This feeling is universal, deeply human, and completely wrong. A coin does not remember its last flip. A shoe does not compensate for previous results. The probability of the next hand is approximately 45.8% Banker, 44.6% Player, 9.6% Tie — every single hand, regardless of what came before.

SYSTEM COMPARISON

Flat Bet [Lowest Risk]
`Same bet every hand. Slowest variance. Best for long sessions.`

Paroli [Low Risk]
`Win: double (max 3×), then reset. You only risk original stake on streaks.`

1-3-2-6 [Medium Risk]
`Bet 1→3→2→6 units, reset on any loss. Captures 4-win runs without deep exposure.`

Fibonacci [Medium Risk]
`1·1·2·3·5·8·13·21… Step back 2 on win. Slower escalation than Martingale.`

Martingale [High Risk]
`Double after every loss. Reset on win. 6 losses = 64× your base unit. Table limits make recovery impossible.`

WHAT SYSTEMS ARE ACTUALLY GOOD FOR

Systems create structure. A player with a plan bets more consistently, chases less, and leaves the table on schedule. Flat betting or Paroli on Banker — with a fixed stop-loss and win goal — is not a winning

strategy. But it is a *losing less badly* strategy, and over a lifetime of sessions, that gap compounds.

> **The one honest edge:** Banker at 1.06% is genuinely the best bet at the table. Betting Banker flat every hand — no system, no switching — minimises expected losses more reliably than any other approach.

6 Bankroll & Session Management

Baccarat's house edge is so small that how you manage your money matters more than almost any other decision you make at the table. A player who bets Banker every hand but manages sessions poorly will lose more than a player who occasionally makes suboptimal bets but leaves on schedule.

HOW MUCH TO BRING

A standard rule: bring at least **50× the table minimum** as your session bankroll. At a $25 minimum table, that's $1,250. This gives you enough runway to weather normal variance without being forced out by a short losing run.

Table Minimum	Recommended Session Bankroll	Expected Loss (1hr, Banker only)
$10	$500	~$6 – $12
$25	$1,250	~$15 – $30
$100	$5,000	~$60 – $120
$500	$25,000	~$300 – $600

THE FOUR SESSION RULES

Rule	Threshold	Why It Works
Stop-loss	Lose 40% of session bankroll → leave	Prevents catastrophic single-session losses
Win goal	Up 30–50% → pocket the profit, play with winnings only	Locks in wins; you can't leave a winner a loser
Time limit	Set a hard end time before you sit down	Removes the "just one more hand" trap
Bet sizing	Single bet ≤ 2–5% of session bankroll	Prevents one hand from deciding the session

THE KELLY CRITERION — SIMPLIFIED

The Kelly Criterion is a bankroll formula used by professional gamblers and investors. In a negative-edge game like baccarat, it technically says bet zero. But adapted for recreational play, the insight is: **bet a small, fixed fraction of your total bankroll**, never a fixed dollar amount.

At $10,000 total bankroll, 1% per bet = $100. After losing $2,000, 1% = $80. This naturally reduces bet size during downswings and scales up during winning periods, extending your playing time and reducing ruin risk.

The cardinal sin: Increasing bet size to "win back" losses. Every hand is independent. A larger bet after a loss does not improve your odds — it only means you lose more on the next loss.

7 The Mental Game

The casino is engineered for your psychological disadvantage. No clocks. No windows. Oxygen-rich air, free drinks, comfortable chairs, and a layout designed to make the exit feel far away. You don't need to beat the house edge to have a profitable session — you need to beat your own psychology first.

TILT

Borrowed from poker, "tilt" describes the state where emotional frustration causes irrational betting. In baccarat, it typically looks like: a streak of losses → frustrated increase in bet size → more losses → maximum bet placed on Tie "to get it back." The Tie bet has a 14.36% house edge. Tilt doesn't create that bet; it removes the self-control that would otherwise prevent it.

> **Tilt signal:** If you've increased your bet size because you're losing, you are on tilt. Stand up, walk away from the table, and do not return for at least 20 minutes.

LOSS AVERSION

Behavioural economists have found that losses feel roughly twice as painful as equivalent gains feel pleasurable. Losing $100 hurts more than winning $100 feels good. At the baccarat table, this creates a dangerous asymmetry: players take on more risk to avoid locking in a loss than they would to secure an equivalent gain. The stop-loss rule in Chapter 6 exists specifically to override this instinct.

THE GAMBLER'S FALLACY IN PRACTICE

After seven consecutive Banker wins, the most common bet in the room is Player. The logic: "it has to switch eventually." The reality: the shoe has no memory. The probability of the 8th hand being Banker is the same as the first. If anything, a long Banker streak slightly increases the probability of another Banker win, because the composition of remaining cards in the shoe is marginally Banker-favourable — but this effect is tiny and not actionable.

RULES FOR THE MENTAL GAME

Situation	Rule
Down 40% of session bankroll	**Leave. No exceptions.**
Up significantly — feel invincible	**Pocket 50% of winnings. Play with the rest.**
Considering a Tie bet	**Ask yourself if you're chasing. You probably are.**
Considering a larger-than-normal bet	**Why? If the answer involves recent losses, don't.**
Feeling unlucky, frustrated, or angry	**Leave now. Emotion and baccarat do not mix.**

"The most dangerous player at any baccarat table is the one who is almost even."

8 The Casino Experience

TABLE TYPES

Format	Players	Minimums	Feel
Full-size	Up to 14	$25–$500+	Formal, slower, squeeze allowed
Midi	Up to 9	$15–$100	More social, moderate pace
Mini	Up to 7	$5–$25	Fastest, no squeeze, dealer-only cards
VIP/High Limit	Private room	$500–$100,000+	Curtained rooms, personal hosts, full squeeze

TABLE SELECTION

Not all baccarat tables are equal. Look for: low commission (some tables offer 4% instead of 5%), fewer decks (6-deck shoes have marginally better odds than 8-deck), and EZ Baccarat if Dragon 7 appeals to you. Avoid tables with unusually high minimum bets relative to your bankroll.

MACAU VS. LAS VEGAS VS. ONLINE

Macau: The world capital of baccarat. Minimum bets start at HK$100 (~$13) but VIP rooms require junket introductions. The squeeze is standard. Roads are shown on every table. 85%+ of revenue from baccarat.

Las Vegas: Baccarat rooms typically open late afternoon. Strip casinos have $25–$50 minimums, downtown as low as $5. Less ritual than Macau but the game is identical. High-limit rooms available at most major properties.

Online: Live dealer baccarat streams from real casino studios with real cards and real dealers. The squeeze is shown on camera. Minimums as low as $1. No tips, no travel, no dress code — but also no room energy.

VIP CULTURE & TABLE RESERVATIONS

VIP baccarat rooms operate differently from the main floor. In Macau, access typically requires a junket agent — a third party who fronts credit and arranges the introduction to the casino host. In Las Vegas, high-limit rooms are more accessible: a casino host can reserve a private table for you with a phone call, usually requiring proof of credit line or a recent play history. At top Strip properties, VIP players can **reserve a specific table** in advance — contact the casino's baccarat host (not the general concierge) at least 24 hours ahead for the best results.

THE COMP SYSTEM — WHAT CASINOS GIVE VIPS

Casinos track every bet you make. That data feeds into a **comp (complimentary) system** that rewards consistent, high-volume play with free goods and services. In baccarat, where bet sizes tend to be larger than other table games, the comps can be substantial.

How comps are calculated: The standard formula is *Average Bet × Hands Per Hour × Hours Played × House Edge × Comp Rate*. Most casinos return 25–40% of your theoretical loss as comps. A player betting $500/hand for 3 hours at 60 hands/hour generates roughly $950 in theoretical loss — worth $238–$380 in comps.

Play Level	Typical Comps
Casual ($25–$100/hand)	Buffet, show tickets, discounted room rate
Midlevel ($100–$500/hand)	Free room, meals at signature restaurants, concert tickets, spa credits
High Roller ($500–$5,000/hand)	Full suite comps, airfare reimbursement, private dining, limo transfer, golf rounds
Whale ($5,000+/hand)	Private jet, penthouse suite, personal host on call, international travel packages

How to access comps: Always play with a player's card inserted (or give your name to the pit boss before sitting). In Las Vegas, ask to be introduced to the *casino host* — not the host desk, but the host assigned to table games. In Macau, junket agents negotiate comp packages in advance, often including round-trip flights, hotel, and a credit line.

> **Practical tip:** Ask your casino host about airfare reimbursement after any significant session. Many Vegas properties will reimburse flights for players averaging $300+/hand, even on first visits — but only if you ask.

FREE HANDS

Most casinos allow players to **"sit out" a hand without betting** — this is sometimes called a *free hand* or *open hand*. You watch the outcome without risking chips. This is useful when you want to observe a new shoe, track road patterns before committing, or take a mental break without leaving the table.

Free hands are typically limited: **regular players can usually sit out up to 10 consecutive hands** before a floor supervisor asks them to bet or vacate the seat. **VIP and high-limit players often receive 20 or more free hands** as a courtesy — especially in Macau, where long sessions and patient road-reading are part of the culture. If you plan to use free hands frequently, establish a relationship with the dealer or floor host first.

TIPPING

In live baccarat, tipping the dealer is customary but not mandatory. Standard practice: tip after a natural 8 or 9, after winning a side bet, or at the end of a winning session. A common method is to place a "for the dealer" bet alongside your own — if it wins, so does the tip. In Macau, tipping is less common than in Las Vegas.

ETIQUETTE AT A GLANCE

- ✅ Place bets before "no more bets"
- ✅ Handle squeeze cards with one hand
- ✅ Keep chips stacked in your zone
- ✅ Know table minimum before sitting

- ❌ Touch bet after "no more bets"
- ❌ Violently crease or damage cards
- ❌ Give unsolicited advice to others
- ❌ Blame the dealer for losing hands

9 Famous Hands & Characters

Phil Ivey — The $20 Million Edge-Sorting Case

Phil Ivey, widely considered the greatest poker player alive, won approximately $20 million across two baccarat sessions — $9.6M at Borgata Atlantic City and £7.7M at Crockfords London — using a technique called **edge sorting**. By identifying microscopic manufacturing defects in the card backs, Ivey's partner could identify high-value cards before they were turned over, giving him a significant advantage.

The casinos refused to pay. Ivey sued. The case went to the UK Supreme Court and the US District Court for New Jersey. Both courts ruled against Ivey — not because edge sorting was illegal per se, but because Ivey's method constituted cheating under casino contract law. The $20 million was never collected.

The case permanently changed how casinos handle card rotation and shuffling procedures worldwide.

Akio Kashiwagi — The $10 Million Session

In the early 1990s, Japanese real estate mogul Akio Kashiwagi flew to Trump Plaza in Atlantic City for a prearranged baccarat session. The terms were extraordinary: $200,000-per-hand minimum, play until either Kashiwagi won $12 million or lost $12 million. He lost $10 million in three days before leaving to attend to business.

Kashiwagi returned to finish the session later that year. He was murdered at his home in Japan before the rematch could take place. The case was never solved. The $10 million loss stood.

Kerry Packer — The Biggest Baccarat Player in History

Australian media billionaire Kerry Packer was the most feared high-roller casino operators ever encountered. His standard baccarat bet was $200,000–$250,000 per hand. He once reportedly won $20 million in a single Las Vegas session, and lost $28 million in another. MGM Grand is said to have lost $33 million to him over multiple visits in the 1990s.

Packer was also known for extraordinary generosity — tipping dealers $100,000+ after winning sessions and once allegedly paying off the mortgages of an entire casino staff shift after a big win.

James Bond — Baccarat's Most Famous Player

Ian Fleming's James Bond played Chemin de Fer — the original French variant — in the 1952 novel *Casino Royale* and in films from *Dr. No* (1962) through *GoldenEye* (1995). The game's aristocratic associations and fixed-odds structure suited Bond's character perfectly: elegant, controlled, fatalistic.

In the 2006 film reboot of *Casino Royale*, baccarat was replaced by Texas Hold'em poker — a reflection of the poker boom of the early 2000s, not a change in Bond's character. For 40 years, Bond at the baccarat table was one of cinema's defining images of cool under pressure.

10 Variants

PUNTO BANCO — THE STANDARD GAME

What this guide describes throughout — and what you find in virtually every casino in North America, Macau, and online. The casino banks every hand. Fixed rules apply automatically. Players have no decisions beyond where to bet. Also called North American Baccarat.

CHEMIN DE FER — THE ORIGINAL

The French variant brought to Charles VIII's court in the 1490s and immortalised by James Bond. Players take turns acting as Banker, betting against each other rather than the house. The Banker has limited discretion over whether to draw a third card. The casino takes a commission from the Banker's winnings.

Chemin de Fer has almost entirely disappeared from American casinos but remains available in some European establishments, particularly in France. It plays faster and feels more intimate — six to eight players around an oval table, passing the shoe.

BACCARAT BANQUE

A variation of Chemin de Fer where one player acts as Banker for an entire session rather than passing the role. The Banker position goes to the player willing to stake the largest amount. Two Player hands are dealt simultaneously against the single Banker hand. Rare outside France and Monte Carlo.

MINI-BACCARAT

The same Punto Banco rules at a blackjack-sized table. The dealer handles all cards — no squeeze, no player-touched cards. Faster pace (up to 200 hands per hour versus 40–60 at a full table). Lower minimums. The mathematically identical game in a more casual setting.

EZ BACCARAT

Removes the 5% Banker commission. Instead, a Banker three-card total of 7 pushes. Dragon 7 (40:1) and Panda 8 (25:1) side bets are available. The no-commission structure appeals to casual players who find commission confusing. House edge is comparable to standard baccarat.

TIGER BACCARAT

A commission-free variant with three additional side bets targeting Banker totals of 6: Big Tiger (3-card 6, 50:1), Small Tiger (2-card 6, 22:1), and Tiger Tie (both hands score 6, 35–45:1). Gaining popularity in Las Vegas and online.

GOLDEN FROG — PALMS & RED ROCK CASINO SIDE BETS

The **Golden Frog** is a proprietary set of baccarat side bets first introduced at the Palms Casino in Las Vegas (also available at Red Rock Resort). Each bet wins when one hand's total beats another's by a specific combination of card count and value. Documented by Wizard of Odds in August 2019.

Bet	Trigger	Payout	House Edge
Any 8 Beats Any 6	Either hand totals 8 and defeats a hand totaling 6	**25:1**	**21.79%**
2-Card 9 Beats 2-Card 7	A two-card 9 hand defeats a two-card 7 hand	**50:1**	8.10%
3-Card 9 Beats 3-Card 1	A three-card 9 hand defeats a three-card 1 hand	**150:1**	**13.87%**
3-Card 9 Beats 3-Card 7	A three-card 9 hand defeats a three-card 7 hand	**200:1**	**11.89%**

Source: Wizard of Odds. Golden Frog bets are available at select casinos only. Always confirm current availability and payouts at your table.

The lesson: baccarat side bet menus vary significantly by property. High-traffic casinos frequently experiment with proprietary bets to differentiate their tables. The Golden Frog's "9 beats 7" bets have more reasonable edges (~8–12%) than flashier longshots, but still far exceed the 1.06% Banker house edge. Always check the posted odds sheet before sitting down.

ONLINE & SPEED BACCARAT

Live dealer online baccarat streams from professional studios with multiple camera angles and real cards. Speed Baccarat plays a hand in approximately 27 seconds rather than the standard 48 seconds — cards are dealt face-up with no squeeze. Some studios offer Squeeze Baccarat as a premium stream where the dealer performs the squeeze on camera for all players.

> **Practice all variants free:** Baccarat Gladiator includes Standard, EZ, and Tiger modes — all free, no account required. Practice the third-card rules, read the roads, and try the theatrical card squeeze at **BaccaratGladiator.com**

Baccarat Gladiator is for entertainment purposes. Please gamble responsibly.
If you or someone you know has a gambling problem, call **1-800-522-4700** (National Problem Gambling Helpline).